

The same colour can represent a different process

Shape, margins and the relationship to vessels help locate a retinal lesion.

Lesion shape and depth

Finding	Meaning
Cotton wool spot	Fluffy nerve fibre layer infarct.
Hard exudate	Sharp yellow lipid/protein deposit from leakage.
Drusen	Deposits between RPE and Bruch membrane.
Dot and blot blood	Deeper intraretinal haemorrhage.

Clinical meaning

Preretinal blood can form a boat-shaped level and obscure vessels; subretinal blood lies beneath visible vessels. Describe location, border and distribution before naming the disease. The cherry red spot in CRAO is contrasting foveal choroidal colour, not focal haemorrhage. Different yellow or pale lesions represent different mechanisms.

Choose the test for the clinical question

Retinal structure, vascular leakage and photoreceptor function need different investigations.

Choose the investigation

Clinical question	Test
Fluid, thickness or traction?	OCT: retinal cross section.
Leakage or non-perfusion?	Fluorescein angiography.
Retina hidden by opaque media?	B-scan ocular ultrasound.
Rod or cone function?	ERG: retinal dystrophy assessment.

Clinical meaning

On OCT, an ERM is a bright contracting surface line; central serous change has fluid lifting a layer and may relate to steroid exposure. Vitreomacular traction tents the fovea. Night blindness with bone-spicule pigmentation suggests RP. Compare matching OCT locations when monitoring structural change.